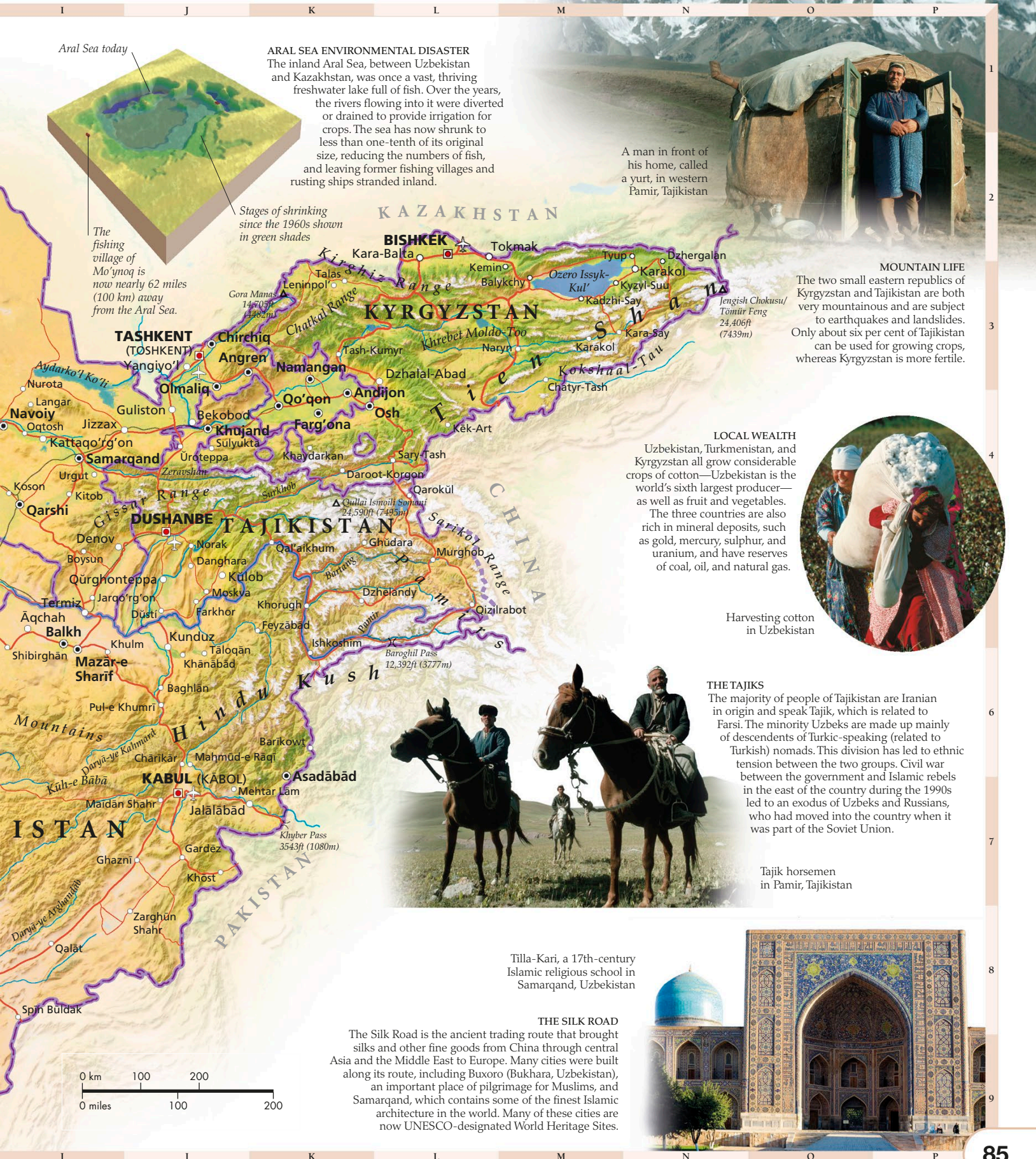




A man in front of his home, called a yurt, in western Pamir, Tajikistan

MOUNTAIN LIFE

The two small eastern republics of Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan are both very mountainous and are subject to earthquakes and landslides. Only about six per cent of Tajikistan can be used for growing crops, whereas Kyrgyzstan is more fertile.

LOCAL WEALTH

Uzbekistan, Turkmenistan, and Kyrgyzstan all grow considerable crops of cotton—Uzbekistan is the world's sixth largest producer—as well as fruit and vegetables. The three countries are also rich in mineral deposits, such as gold, mercury, sulphur, and uranium, and have reserves of coal, oil, and natural gas.

Harvesting cotton in Uzbekistan

THE TAJIKS

The majority of people of Tajikistan are Iranian in origin and speak Tajik, which is related to Farsi. The minority Uzbeks are made up mainly of descendants of Turkic-speaking (related to Turkish) nomads. This division has led to ethnic tension between the two groups. Civil war between the government and Islamic rebels in the east of the country during the 1990s led to an exodus of Uzbeks and Russians, who had moved into the country when it was part of the Soviet Union.

Tajik horsemen in Pamir, Tajikistan

Tilla-Kari, a 17th-century Islamic religious school in Samarqand, Uzbekistan

THE SILK ROAD

The Silk Road is the ancient trading route that brought silks and other fine goods from China through central Asia and the Middle East to Europe. Many cities were built along its route, including Buxoro (Bukhara, Uzbekistan), an important place of pilgrimage for Muslims, and Samarqand, which contains some of the finest Islamic architecture in the world. Many of these cities are now UNESCO-designated World Heritage Sites.